Shel Silverstein Program

By Shel Silverstein

"Listen to the mustn'ts, child. Listen to the don'ts. Listen to the shouldn'ts, the impossibles, the won'ts. Listen to the never haves, then listen close to me . . . Anything can happen, child. Anything can be." -- Shel Silverstein

INTRODUCTION

Shel Silverstein is one of America's most celebrated children's poets. And while there is poetry appropriate for every age, the best lessons may come from the lines intended for children. With stanzas that make us laugh and reflect, Shel Silverstein wrote for kids -- and the kid inside all of us. In fact, the sheer joy I recall feeling while reading his poems is one of the fondest memories of my childhood. This collection of poetry comes from two of Silversteins's popular publications: Where the Sidewalk Ends and A Light in the Attic.

INVITATION

If you are a dreamer, come in,

If you are a dreamer, a wisher, a liar,

A hope-er, a pray-er, a magic bean buyer. . .

If you're a pretender, come sit by my fire

4NG Fanatics

For we have some flax-golden tales to spin.

Come in!

Come in!

OVERDUES

What do I do?

What do I do?

This library book is 42

Years overdue.

I admit that it's mine

But I can't pay the fine –

Should I turn it in

Or hide it again?

What do I do?

What do I do?

PRAYER OF THE SHELFISH CHILD

Now I lay me down to sleep,

I pray the Lord my soul to keep,

And if I die before I wake,

I pray the Lord my toys to break.

So none of the other kids can use 'em. . . .

Amen.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

FOR SALE

One sister for sale!

One sister for sale!

One crying and spying young sister for sale!

I'm really not kidding,

So who'll start the bidding?

Do I hear a dollar?

A nickel?

A penny?

Oh, isn't there, isn't there, isn't there any

One kid who will buy this old sister for sale,

This crying and spying young sister for sale?

HOW NOT TO HAVE TO DRY THE DISHES

If you have to dry the dishes

(Such an awful, boring chore)

If you have to dry the dishes

('Stead of going to the store)

If you have to dry the dishes

And you drop one on the floor—

Maybe they won't let you

Dry the dishes anymore.

4NG Fanatics

WAVY HAIR

I thought that I had wavy hair

Until I shaved. Instead

I find that I have straight hair

And a very wavy head.

BOA CONSTRICTOR

Oh, I'm being eaten

By a boa constrictor

A boa constrictor,

A boa constrictor,

I'm being eaten by a boa constrictor,

And I don't like it – one bit.

Well, what do you know?

It's nibblin' my toe.

Oh, gee,

It's up to my knee.

Oh my,

It's up to my thigh.

Oh, fiddle,

It's up to my middle.

Oh, heck,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

It's up to my neck.

Oh, dread,

It's upmmmmmmmmmfffffffff…

SICK

"I cannot go to school today,"

Said little Peggy Ann McKay.

"I have the measles and the mumps,

A gash, a rash and purple bumps.

My mouth is wet, my throat is dry,

I'm going blind in my right eye.

My tonsils are as big as rocks,

I've counted sixteen chicken pox

And there's one more – that's seventeen,

And don't you think my face looks green?

My leg is cut, my eyes are blue –

It might be instamatic flu.

I cough and sneeze and gasp and choke,

I'm sure that my left leg is broke –

My hip hurts when I move my chin,

My belly button's caving in,

My back is wrenched, my ankle's sprained,

4N6 Fanatics

My 'pendix pains each time it rains.

My nose is cold, my toes are numb,

I have a sliver in my thumb.

My neck is stiff, my voice is weak,

I hardly whisper when I speak.

My tongue is filling up my mouth

I think my hair is falling out.

My elbow's bent, my spine ain't straight,

My temperature is one-o-eight.

My brain is shrunk, I cannot hear,

There is a hole inside my ear.

I have a hangnail, and my heart is – what?

What's that? What's that you say?

You say today is . . . Saturday?

G'bye, I'm going out to play!"

MY RULES

If you want to marry me, here's what you'll have to do:

You must learn how to make a perfect chicken-dumpling stew.

And you must sew my holey socks,

And soothe my troubled mind,

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

And develop the knack for scratching my back,
And keep my shoes spotlessly shined.
And while I rest you must rake up the leaves,
And when it is hailing and snowing
You must shovel the walk . . . and be still when I talk,
And – hey—where are you going?

DEAF DONALD

Deaf Donald met Talkie Sue
But (sign language for I love you) was all he could do.

And Sue said, "Donald, I sure do like you."
But (sign language for I love you) was all he could do.

And Sue Asked Donald, "Do you like me too?"
But (sign language for I love you) was all he could do.

"Good-bye then, Donald, I'm leaving you."
But (sign language for I love you) was all he could do.

And she left forever so she never knew
That (sign language for I love you) means I love you.

4NG Fanatics

SMART

My dad gave me one dollar bill
'Cause I'm his smartest son,
And I swapped it for two shiny quarters
'Cause two is more than one!

And then I took the quarters
And traded them to Lou
For three dimes – I guess he don't know
That three is more than two!

Just then, along came old blind Bates
And just 'cause he can't see
He gave me four nickels for my three dimes,
And four is more than three!

And I took the nickels to Hiram Coombs
Down at the seed-feed store,
And the fool gave me five pennies for them,
And five is more than four!

And then I went and showed my dad,
And he got red in the cheeks

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

And closed his eyes and shook his head –

Too proud of me to speak!

HOMEWORK MACHINE

The Homework Machine, oh the Homework Machine,

Most perfect contraption that's ever been seen.

Jut put in your homework, then drop in a dime,

Snap on the switch, and in ten seconds' time,

Your homework comes out, quick and clean as can be.

Here it is –"nine plus four?" and the answer is "three."

Three?

Oh me . . .

I guess it's not as perfect

As I thought it would be.

WHERE THE SIDEWALK ENDS

There is a place where the sidewalk ends

And before the street begins

And there the grass grows soft and white,

And there the sun burns crimson bright,

And there the moon-bird rests from his flight

To cool in the peppermint wind.

4NG Fanatics

Let us leave this place where the smoke blows black

And the dark street winds and bends.

Past the pits where the asphalt flowers grow

We shall walk with a walk that is measured and slow

And watch where the chalk-white arrows go

To the place where the sidewalk ends.

Yes we'll walk with a walk that is measured and slow

And we'll go where the chalk-white arrows go

For the children, they mark, and the children, they know

The place where the sidewalk ends.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

4NG Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

For Sale, Boa Constrictor, Sick, Smart and Where the Sidewalk Ends
Author: Shel Silverstein
Book: Where the Side Walk Ends
ISBN: 978-0060256678
Publisher: HarperCollins
Date (Month/Year): Nov 1974

Invitation, Overdues, Prayer of the Selfish Child, How Not to Have to Dry the Dishes, Wavy Hair, Deaf Donald and Homework Machine
Author: Shel Silverstein
Book: A Light in the Attic
ISBN: 978-0060256739
Publisher: HarperCollins
Date (Month/Year): Oct 1981

AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
2021 National Qualifier – MS
CO State Qualifier

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY